

EXPERIENTIAL LEARNING SYSTEM AND PROCESS FOR DEVELOPING FUNCTIONAL SELF-AWARENESS AND EFFECTUATING SUSTAINABLE BEHAVIOR CHANGES

BACKGROUND

[001] Embodiments of the invention described in this specification relate generally to behavior change models, and more particularly, to self-awareness, mindfulness, and behavior change systems and processes that bring about predictable and sustainable behavior changes.

[002] Traditional behavior change models rely primarily on a cognitive approach directed at the neocortex, rather than a whole brain approach involving the limbic system and the amygdala of a person's brain; and they do not address the person's dysfunctional emotional and behavioral programmed responses embedded in the neural pathways of the person's brain.

[003] However, such repetitive and addictive behavioral patterns are problematic when a person's compulsion to continue engaging in behavior that is consistent with conditioned response patterns results in impairment of the person's perception, functioning, and relationships, or which may negatively affect the person's health.

[004] Therefore, what is needed is a way to dissolve repetitive and addictive behavioral patterns by a self-management approach involving a sequence steps that build a person's practical mindfulness and resilience to support behavioral change.

BRIEF DESCRIPTION

[005] Some embodiments include a novel experiential learning system and a novel experiential learning process for developing functional self-awareness and effectuating sustainable behavior changes. In some embodiments, the experiential learning system combines aspects of psychometrics and practical mindfulness in an experiential learning model through which functional self-awareness of a person is developed to effectuate behavior changes in the person. In some embodiments, the experiential learning model comprises a sequential behavioral blueprint by which the person is able to effectuate predictable, sustainable behavior changes.

[006] In some embodiments, the experiential learning process for developing functional self-awareness and effectuating sustainable behavior changes guides the person

through a sequence of experiential learning stages. In some embodiments, the experiential learning process guides the person through a sequence of six experiential learning stages. In some embodiments, the sequence of six experiential learning stages of the experiential learning process allows the person to dissolve past conditioning and develop functional self-awareness. The experiential learning process of some embodiments encourages self-management which leads to lasting behavior change in the person.

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[007] Having thus described the invention in general terms, reference is now made to the accompanying drawings, which are not necessarily drawn to scale, and which show different views of different example embodiments.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

[008] In the following detailed description of the invention, numerous details, examples, and embodiments of the invention are described. However, it will be clear and apparent to one skilled in the art that the invention is not limited to the embodiments set forth and that the invention can be adapted for any of several applications.

[009] As noted above, traditional behavior change models rely primarily on a cognitive approach rather than a whole brain approach of a person's brain. The existing traditional behavior change models also fail to account for any or all of a person's dysfunctional emotional and/or behavioral programmed responses, which have developed as strong neural pathways in the person's brain. This is a problem for people with destructive or negative behavior patterns that are repetitive or addictive, especially when the person feels compelled to continue engaging in the destructive or negative behavior. As a conditioned response pattern is strengthened by unbridled repetitive performance of the destructive or negative behavior, countless other aspects of the person are weakened, compromised, or otherwise negatively affected, including impairment of the person's perception, functioning, and relationships, or a chronic negative toll on the person's health.

[0010] Embodiments of the invention described in this specification address and solve these problems. In particular, these problems are addressed and solved by embodiments of an experiential learning system and by an experiential learning process for developing functional

self-awareness and effectuating sustainable behavior changes. When applied to any other change model, the experiential learning system and the experiential learning process increases the effectiveness of the other change model.

[0011] Due to the cognitive approach of existing traditional behavior change models which exist today, many aspects of a person and/or a person's brain are discarded, discounted, or ignored. For instance, various dysfunctional aspects of a person's brain may have a strong impact on behavior. Yet none of the traditional behavior change models effectively address mental, personality, and/or repetitive/addictive aspects of a person's brain. This often leads to unpredictable behavior changes (if any) or difficulty in the person being able to self-manage any positive behavior changes (leading to no self-actualized behavior changes, or at best, only temporary behavior changes that are constantly stressed).

[0012] In contrast, embodiments of the experiential learning system described in this disclosure combines aspects of psychometrics and practical mindfulness in an experiential learning model through which functional self-awareness of a person is developed to effectuate behavior changes in the person. In some embodiments, the experiential learning model comprises a sequential behavioral blueprint by which the person is able to effectuate predictable, sustainable behavior changes.

[0013] The experiential learning process facilitates the development of functional self-awareness which can effectuate sustainable behavior changes in the person. In some embodiments, the experiential learning process guides the person through a sequence of experiential learning stages which enable the person to effectively self-manage and sustain positive behavior changes that are long lasting. In some embodiments, the sequence of experiential learning stages comprises a sequence of six experiential learning stages. In some embodiments, the sequence of six experiential learning stages of the experiential learning process allows the person to dissolve past conditioning and develop functional self-awareness.

[0014] Furthermore, repetitive and addictive behavioral patterns are problematic when a person's compulsion to continue engaging in behavior that is consistent with conditioned response patterns results in impairment of the person's perception, functioning, and relationships, or which may negatively affect the person's health. However, by using a whole-brain approach

that involves cognitive responsiveness (neocortex), long-term conditioned, addictive, and/or habitual responsiveness (limbic), and emotional/mental responsiveness (amygdala), the experiential learning process increases a person's awareness and empowers the person to bridge the gap between desired outcomes (hoped for by the person) and automatic behaviors (resulting from past conditioning, experience, etc.). In this way, the person is able to moderate immediate cognitive-based behavior and habitual or conditioned response patterns.

[0015] In some embodiments, the experiential learning system and process also encourage the person to take personal responsibility for their own experiences, feelings, and resistance to change. In some embodiments, the experiential learning system and process build resilience by predictably dissolving, eliminating, or otherwise reducing the person's existing compulsion to continue engaging in destructive or negative behavior that is brought evident in their conditioned response patterns and which impair the person's perception, functioning, relationships, and health.

[0016] Embodiments of the experiential learning system and process described in this specification differ from and improve upon currently existing change models. In particular, some embodiments of the experiential learning system and process differ because existing change models or traditional behavioral change systems operate from the outside in rather than from the inside out, relying on externally invoked motivation which must be continually reinforced. In other words, they start at point of trauma. However, they do not release core anxiety of a person's conditioned response. Furthermore, traditional behavioral change systems do not access natural emotional intelligence of a person and, therefore, do not create sustainable change. In contrast, the experiential learning system and process of the present disclosure start by accessing the original interpersonal connection that existed naturally before a person experienced sustained trauma or felt a need to hide or change the person's authentic self. Some embodiments of the experiential learning system and process stimulate the limbic system (the brain's seat of memory and emotion), amygdala, and the neocortex to reprogram the brain, creating new neural pathways, and minimizing the need for the "fight or flight" response to present day situations.

[0017] The experiential learning system and process also improves upon the currently existing options by providing objectively quantified improvements demonstrated in brain

imaging (i.e., magnetic resonance imaging (MRI) results improve over time while a person proceeds through the six sequential steps of the experiential learning process), stress response tests (i.e., facilitated or supported stress tests, self-administered stress tests, etc.), and empirical evidence of success when implemented and used in recovery centers (i.e., alcohol and/or drug addiction recovery, trauma recovery, etc.).

[0018] The experiential learning system and process of the present disclosure may be comprised of the following elements. This list of possible constituent elements is intended to be exemplary only and it is not intended that this list be used to limit the experiential learning system and process of the present application to just these elements. Persons having ordinary skill in the art relevant to the present disclosure may understand there to be equivalent elements that may be substituted within the present disclosure without changing the essential function or operation of the experiential learning system and process.

[0019] 1. Insight, awareness and acceptance of the origin of a person's beliefs, values, and points of view.

[0020] 2. Personal Responsibility, where the person is the source and authority of the person's own experience; seeing many options rather than "either/or" (or black/white).

[0021] 3. Authenticity, being genuine, whole and connected.

[0022] 4. Integrity, the person has personal integrity (being that the person is his or her own word, the person can walk the person's talk)

[0023] 5. Clear Mind, in which the person is in a state of being without bias or preconceptions

[0024] 6. Awakened Action, the person's behavior is motivated by the person's own will and for the benefit of the person and others (not just self-beneficial action).

[0025] The various elements of the experiential learning system and process of the present disclosure may be related in the following exemplary fashion. It is not intended to limit the scope or nature of the relationships between the various elements and the following examples are presented as illustrative examples only. These steps must be done in the assigned order. Each principle has components that become part of a daily practice.

[0026] (1) Insight - knowing where beliefs, values and points of view come from.

Once a person has Insight, the person moves to the next stage.

[0027] (2) Personal Responsibility for those beliefs, values and experiences. When a person knows the core reasons for the person's own and other people's actions, it becomes possible for the person to take responsibility for our experience without blame. After this stage, the person moves to authenticity.

[0028] (3) The person at this stage strives to become truly authentic, thereby allowing the person to naturally live with integrity (the next stage).

[0029] (4) Integrity, which that quality of the person of keeping our word. After the first four steps are completed the last two follow. That is, once the person gains self-awareness and can be his or her true authentic self, the person is able to view the world clearly.

[0030] (5) Clear Mind, or without blame or judgment. The person can then pass that knowledge on to others (e.g., through the next stage)

[0031] (6) Awakened Action, or behavior that is motivated for the benefit of all.

[0032] The experiential learning system and process of the present disclosure generally works by a sequence of the six steps which are designed to progress an individual.

[0033] 1. Insight: This component forms the basis from which all following components flow. The goal of this step is to enable true understanding of oneself and the origin of the behaviors that one engages in. Without this understanding, further action will not be effective, since it will lack the foundation of understanding and awareness of one's automatic responses.

[0034] 2. Personal Responsibility: Once true insight into oneself and the origins of one's behavior is gleaned, the user will be able to be accountable for their behavior and experience, and choose new responses.

[0035] 3. Authenticity: When one has true insight and is able to take responsibility for their behavior, they become truly authentic. They know who they are and why they act in certain ways and can truly be themselves, without conditioned limits.

[0036] 4. Integrity: Once users are their true authentic selves, they are able to live in integrity with themselves and others.

[0037] 5. Clear Mind: By the time users reach this component, they are able to live

without blame, judgment or preconceptions. They are able to be open-minded and unbiased in any situation.

[0038] 6. Awakened Action: This component comes naturally for users. Once they reach this component, users cannot help but behave in a way that is for the benefit to all.

[0039] To make the experiential learning system and process of the present disclosure, a person would implement a process involving and following the sequential behavioral blueprint. For example, the person may develop and code a software application that implements a process for progressing through the sequential behavioral blueprint, ensuring that the six core principles delineated above are available to a user for practical application when engaged by the user.

[0040] In some embodiments, the experiential learning system and process employs specific practices that retrain the brain in a holistic manner, with incorporation of emotional learning to target trauma, compulsive behaviors and negative beliefs, and engage neuroplasticity to sustain this change.

[0041] The experiential learning system and process is based on empirically validated behavioral and neurological research on how the brain is rewired through practical mindfulness, and this is implemented as an algorithm that performs the experiential learning process. Thus, the person may design, develop, and code such a software application in any type of electronic system, cloud-network system, standalone computer program, and by way of other, non-computer methods and mechanisms, such as physical courses, online video or audio-based course, online workbook-based courses, seminars, etc.

[0042] To use the experiential learning system and process of the present disclosure, a user may, in line with the aforementioned manners of making the invention, progress through the six sequential steps by one or more of the following:

[0043] I. Mobile Applications: In this form, the experiential learning process is implemented as an application (e.g., a mobile "app" that runs on a processor of a smartphone), which provides exercises and steps designed to guide the user along the six sequential principles. For example, a mobile app may include one or more of the following: (a) the user is presented with statements that relate to the first Principle: Insight, (b) the user selects statements relevant to

Insight most like him/her; (c) the user receives feedback based on selections; (d) the user selects the type of out-of-app challenge to receive-action or reflection; (e) the user returns later and gives feedback on challenge; feedback may be subsequently used to improve user challenges; and (f) the user receives a new set of statements. Statements, feedback and challenges are progressively more profound as the user advances through the six Principles.

[0044] II. Online Courses: In this form, the experiential learning system is conveyed via virtual courses, which provide exercises, teachings and the benefit of working through the six Principles with a partner in an effort to better understand how others experience the individual.

[0045] III. Physical Courses: In this form, the experiential learning system is conveyed in the same way as with online courses but in a physical setting and focused on a specific issue, such as addiction recovery.

[0046] IV. Certification Programs/Seminars: In this form, individuals learn to work through the six principles with exercises and steps but gain the knowledge and capability to guide others through the six principles as well. They experience that we all already know that which is important to know about human nature by looking at our own experience instead of focusing on the situation or the other person, which brings an experience our unified oneness.

[0047] The aforementioned media are designed to achieve the same goal, predictably eliminating the compulsion to continue conditioned response patterns that impair a person's perception, functioning and relationships, and negatively affect their health. This is achieved through the dismissal of illusions and the realization that one is ultimately accountable for their own behavior and that through true personal insight and commitment to responsibility and integrity, an individual can free themselves from the harmful behaviors and thought patterns that are present in the wake of trauma and negative conditioning.

[0048] The above-described embodiments of the invention are presented for purposes of illustration and not of limitation. While these embodiments of the invention have been described with reference to numerous specific details, one of ordinary skill in the art will recognize that the invention can be embodied in other specific forms without departing from the spirit of the invention. Thus, one of ordinary skill in the art would understand that the invention is not to be limited by the foregoing illustrative details, but rather is to be defined by the

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appended claims.

CLAIMS

I claim:

1. An experiential learning process for developing functional self-awareness by combining psychometrics and practical mindfulness which lead to predictable and sustainable behavior changes in a person, the experiential learning process comprising:
 - developing personal insight, awareness, and acceptance of an origin of personal beliefs, values, and points of view;
 - actuating personal responsibility in which a person is understood to be the source and authority of the person's own experience, thereby allowing the person to see beyond a duality of options in life;
 - realizing an authentic self in which the person is genuine, whole, and connected;
 - strengthening a sense of personal integrity in the person;
 - viewing inner and outer experience in life with a clear mind, wherein the person has a state of mind that is clear of bias and preconceptions; and
 - taking awakened action in which the person's behavior is motivated by the person's own will and for the benefit of the person and others.

ABSTRACT

A system and processes for developing functional self-awareness are disclosed which combine psychometrics and practical mindfulness through six sequential behavioral stages of experiential learning and lead to predictable, sustainable behavior changes in a user. The experiential learning system and processes provide a unique sequential behavioral blueprint that includes a set of instructions for guiding the user through the six stages of experiential learning to dissolve past conditioning and encourage self-management, which thereby develops functional self-awareness and leads to lasting behavior changes. When applied to any other change model, the system and processes for developing functional self-awareness increase the effectiveness of the other change model.